as Rohingyas in the 1961 census, indicating an ongoing recognition of their existence as an ethnic group under that description.[36]

This relative tolerance started to change once the military came to power in 1962. However, the gradual and incremental nature of this process must be stressed. Some Rohingyas supported the military rule and served in parliament as members of the Burmese Socialist Programme Party. However, at the same time the generals were desperately trying to justify their own rule. In addition to their notional socialist allegiance (which in practice meant very little),[37] they decided if they could not have an ethnically pure state (which would have meant giving up all the wealth in the border areas to the north and east), they would use being 'Buddhist' as a test for being a proper citizen of the state.

The 1974 Constitution of the Socialist Republic of the Union of Burma[38] was a critical step as it removed the status the Rohingyas had been granted at independence and insisted that they accept identity cards that described them as 'Foreigners'. This led to a period of sustained violence against the Rohingyas and a large outflow of refugees, mostly to Bangladesh. The 1982 Burmese Citizenship Law[39] took this a step further: it started the modern-day obsession with who had lived in Burma in 1824 by stating that the Rohingyas were now foreigners, since they were deemed not to have lived in Arakan before 1823. In interviews I conducted in 2015 with Myanmar-based journalists and Rohingya politicians (whom I will leave anonymous for their safety), it became clear that this period saw a sustained campaign of propaganda and lies aimed at the Rohingyas to convince the rest of the population that this Muslim minority group, who spoke a language very different to Burmese, had no place in the country.

One question that does persist, and is harder to answer than it might first seem, is exactly why the Rohingyas became such a core target for the regime, Buddhist extremists and the main opposition party. One argument is that they are a convenient target, being different in terms of ethnicity and religion. Another is that they are a safe target, as unlike other ethnic groups such as the Karen or Shan they do not have a long history of armed revolt, apart from the brief unrest in 1947. What is clear is that persecution of the Rohingyas, and the denial of even the most basic of their human rights, has become the one belief that the military, the democratic opposition and the extremists all share. In a perverse kind of way, it is in this ritual of